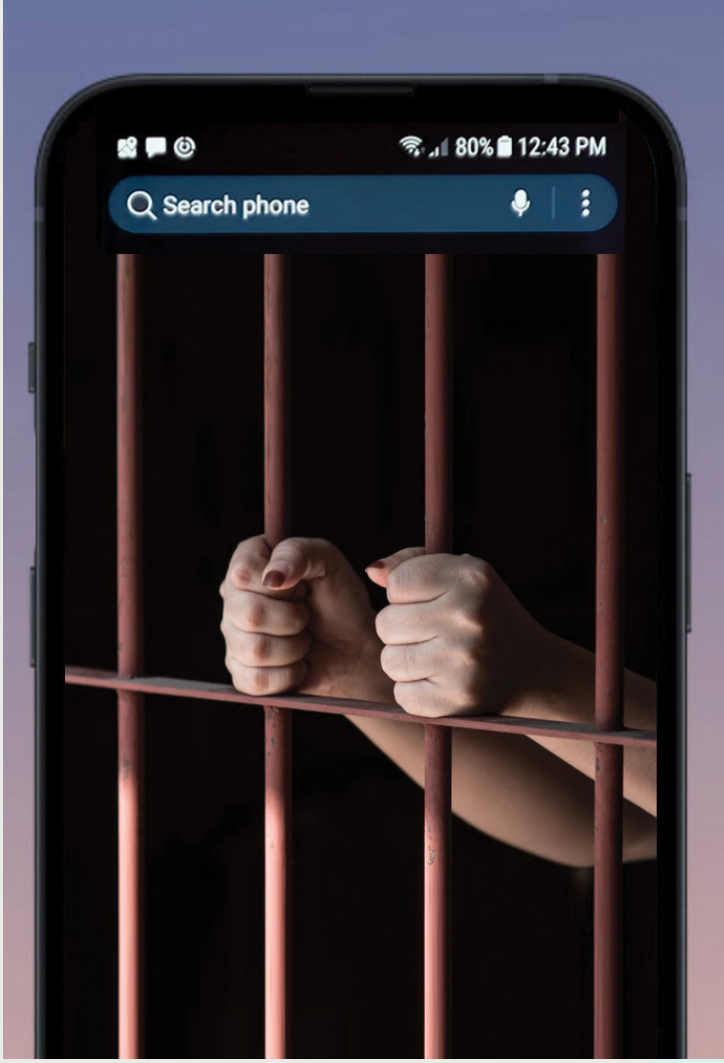
SENIORITY NO BAR

THE ELDERLY ARE AT LEAST AS VULNERABLE AS THE YOUTH WHEN IT COMES TO INTERNET ADDICTION



Abhinav Lal, 63, was looking forward to a quiet retired life with his 60-year-old wife (who does not wish to be named) after he left his job as a banker in Mumbai. The childless couple spent the two years of the Covid lockdown catching up with friends online and watching the latest TV serials. Night after night, Lal would talk for hours with old college friends on Facebook Messenger. He soon began to sleep with his phone under the pillow, a habit he had been firmly against before the pandemic. In January 2022, Lal began to attend counselling for textaphrenia, the pathological fear of not being able to send or receive texts, after he nearly hit his wife because she had accidentally turned off the wi-fi in the middle of his chat session. "We don't get good signal at home," says Lal. "I just felt so angry for a few minutes. I had never felt such rage, at not being able to talk to people online."

"The overuse and over-reliance on the virtual world is as much of an issue with elders as it is with the young," says Dr Kedar Tilwe, a psychiatrist at the Fortis Hospital in Mumbai. "This has been more common after the pandemic as people began to rely heavily on the internet for information and relationship-building. They got used to instant news, instant chatting, instant answers, making the return to offline difficult."

Indeed, a 2020 study by the HRD ministry reported 5.2 hours of daily screen time among those above 65 years old when most doctors recommend no more than two hours of daily screen time in addition to work-related screen time. Unregulated and irrational use of digital devices is shown to have an adverse effect on one's physical and mental health. During Covid, the most commonly reported adverse effects on the elderly were panic, self-diagnosis and insomnia. "People passively absorb what is online without using discretion and judgement," says internal medicine specialist Dr Farah Ingale in Mumbai. "I had patients who were self-medicating for Covid based on online reports. Or patients who could not sleep because of something they read on WhatsApp. They treat online information as the gospel truth." Not only does their constant doomscrolling sharpen their anxieties, they also fall prey to fake news.

"We are seeing a growth in social media- and internet-related anxiety among the elderly since the pandemic as more people are indoors and offline experiences have reduced," says Dr Manoj Sharma, founder of the digital rehab centre at NIMHANS. So, when a message from Zomato told 77-year-old Laxmi Mala that she was now an 'ambassador' for a restaurant she frequently ordered from, the Noida-based widow felt immediately blissful. Having lived all by herself for the past two years in order to escape Covid, the diabetic and breast cancer survivor says the "language of apps, social media and OTT platforms" made her feel "socially connected in the midst of utter loneliness". The problem arose when she began to depend on the digital world for comfort and joy. "My son in Canada began to grow concerned as I became moody and my sleep started getting disturbed due to staring at the screen so often. He then insisted that I go for online therapy," says Mala, who now limits screen time to six hours a day, down from 14. "I haven't grown up with the internet, the language was very flattering and I forgot it was not a real person. My therapist made me understand that online words were the work of marketing agencies." Mala is now slowly returning to reality.